A SOUTH ISLAND ROAD TRIP

NZ NOODLES

QUEENSTOWN → CHRISTCHURCH · 17 DAYS · ONE VAN

7 — 23 NOV 2026
ITINERARY V2



EMOJI KEY

- ✈️ Flights in & out
- 🚐 Driving & the van
- 🥾 Hikes & walks
- ⛺ Huts, campsites & overnight stops
- 🏞️ Explore & sightseeing
- 📸 Photo spots
- 🌅 Sunrise & sunset
- 🌌 Stargazing
- 🏊 Swims
- 🚤 Boat cruise
- 🍽️ Food & drink
- 🛒 Supplies
- 😌 Chill / rest time
- 💸 Optional extra ($)
- ❓ Maybe / if time
- ✅ Booked
- 📝 Still to book
- 🗺️ Bring a map
- ⚠️ Heads-up

DAY BY DAY

SAT 7 — MON 23 NOVEMBER
weather permitting!

SAT 7 — QUEENSTOWN

- ✈️ Courtney lands 2:15pm · Bradley 6:45pm
- 🏞️ Free day · Arrowtown?

SUN 8 — QUEENSTOWN

- 🍽️ Courtney: brunch with a friend
- 🚐 Van pick-up ~3pm, then groceries
- 🌅 **Bob's Cove** sunset?

MON 9 — QUEENSTOWN

COURTNEY HIKING 12 KM

- ✈️ Ruby lands 11:45am
- 🥾 Courtney starts the **Routeburn**
- ✅ Lake Mackenzie Hut booked (1 spot)

TUE 10 — GLENORCHY

HIKING 14 KM · COURTNEY 34 KM

- 🚐 Pick up Courtney at Routeburn Shelter
- 🍽️ Lunch in Glenorchy?
- 🥾 **Earnslaw Burn**, one way — 14 km

WED 11 — GLENORCHY → CASCADE CREEK

BIG DRIVE · 4 HRS

HIKING 14 KM

- 🥾 Hike out of **Earnslaw Burn** — 14 km
- 🏊 Lunch in Glenorchy? · **Bob's Cove** swim?
- 🍽️ Dinner in Te Anau?
- ⛺ Cascade Creek Campsite (4 hr drive from Glenorchy)

THU 12 — MILFORD SOUND → WANAKA

BIG DRIVE · 4¾ HRS

- 🚤 Milford Sound cruise 10:30am–12:30pm (beat the buses)
- 🍽️ Lunch in Te Anau? (1 hr drive from Milford) · early dinner at Cardrona Hotel? (2½ hr drive from Te Anau)
- 🌅 Wanaka ~7:30pm · Wanaka tree, lake sunset

FRI 13 — MT ASPIRING NP

HIKING 16 KM

- 🚐 Drive to Raspberry Flat carpark (1 hr) — arrive before 9am
- 🍽️ Lunch at Aspiring Hut (2–2.5 hr hike from carpark)
- ⛺ **Liverpool Hut** — 10 bunks, 15 km, 5–6.5 hr hike
- ⛺ OR **French Ridge Hut** — 20 bunks, 16.2 km, 6–7.5 hr hike

SAT 14 — MT ASPIRING NP → WANAKA

HIKING 16 KM (+10 OPTIONAL)

- ⛺ Hike out to Raspberry Flat (16.2 km)
- ❓ **Rob Roy Glacier Track** (10 km) if time
- ⛺ Wanaka OR Kidds Bush Campsite, Lake Hawea (paid)

SUN 15 — WEST COAST · FOX GLACIER

OPTIONAL HIKING 17 KM

- 🏞️ Haast Pass, Fox & Franz Josef glaciers
- 🥾 Alex Knob Track — 17.2 km return (or a sightseeing day - no hike)

MON 16 — BREWSTER HUT

HIKING 2.8 KM

- 🚐 Fox Glacier → Fantail Falls carpark
- ⛺ **Brewster Hut** — 4 hr hike up · unbridged river crossing ⚠️
- 📝 3 hut spots booked · need 2 more (hut or camping)

TUE 17 — BREWSTER HUT → WANAKA

HIKING 7–9 KM

- 🥾 Brewster Glacier at dawn — 2–4 hr hike, 4–6 km 🏞️ no track, bring a map
- ⛺ Hike down to Fantail Falls — 4 hrs (2.8 km)
- 🥾 **Blue Pools** — 3.2 km, easy
- 🌅 Wanaka tree, lake sunset

WED 18 — WANAKA → TWIZEL

HIKING 16 KM

- 🌅 **Roys Peak** sunrise — 16 km (3am start, done by 9am)
- 😌 Rest · horse riding?
- 🚐 Drive to Mt Cook area (1¾ hrs) · Lake Pukaki shores
- ⛺ Lake Poaka Campsite, Twizel (free)

THU 19 — AORAKI MT COOK

WEATHER DEPENDENT

- ⛺ **Mueller Hut** (10 km return), **Hooker Valley** (10 km return) and/or Tasman Glacier
- 😌 Or rest day — Lake Pukaki / Tekapo

FRI 20 — AORAKI MT COOK

WEATHER DEPENDENT

- ⛺ **Mueller Hut** (10 km return), **Hooker Valley** (10 km return) and/or Tasman Glacier
- 😌 Or rest day — Lake Pukaki / Tekapo

SAT 21 — AORAKI MT COOK → TEKAPO

WEATHER DEPENDENT

- ⛺ **Mueller Hut** (10 km return), **Hooker Valley** (10 km return) and/or Tasman Glacier
- 🚐 Afternoon drive to Lake Tekapo (1 hr)
- 🌌 Sunset · Church of the Good Shepherd · Dark Sky stargazing 2am ($$)

SUN 22 — TEKAPO → CHRISTCHURCH

- 📸 Lupin fields photoshoot · horse riding?
- 🚐 Drive to Christchurch (3 hrs) via Cookie Time
- ⛺ Park near the airport (backup: LYLO hostel for Courtney & Ruby)

MON 23 — CHRISTCHURCH AIRPORT

- 🚐 Return the van
- ✈️ Ruby flies 6am · Courtney 8am

TRIP AT A GLANCE

ESTIMATES · PER PERSON
roughly speaking!

🥾 **~139 km**
hiking, incl. optional

🔥 **~9,700 kcal**
burned hiking
🍪 ≈ 24 Cookie Time cookies

🚐 **~2,300 km**
driving
~30 hrs in the van

⛺ **5**
hut / tent nights
Courtney 5 · everyone else 4

🥾 THE HIKES

HIKE	REGION	WHEN	DISTANCE	GAIN	TIME
Routeburn Track Courtney	Fiordland	Mon 9–Tue 10	32 km (one way)	~1,300 m	11.5–15 hrs (over 2 days)
Earnslaw Burn overnight	Queenstown	Tue 10–Wed 11	28 km (return)	~890 m	8–12 hrs (over 2 days)
French Ridge / Liverpool Hut overnight	Wanaka	Fri 13–Sat 14	30–32 km (return)	~1,070–1,100 m	12–15 hrs (over 2 days)
Rob Roy Glacier optional	Wanaka	Sat 14	10 km (return)	457 m	3–4 hrs
Alex Knob Track optional	West Coast	Sun 15	17.2 km (return)	1,294 m	6–8 hrs
Brewster Hut overnight	West Coast	Mon 16–Tue 17	5.6 km (return)	965 m	~8 hrs (over 2 days)
Brewster Glacier from Brewster Hut · off-track	West Coast	Tue 17	~6 km (return)	333 m	2.5–4 hrs
Blue Pools easy	Wanaka	Tue 17	3.2 km (return)	~25 m	~1 hr
Roys Peak sunrise	Wanaka	Wed 18	16 km (return)	1,258 m	5–6 hrs
Mueller Hut overnight	Mt Cook & Mackenzie	Thu 19–Sat 21	10.4 km (return)	1,045 m	6–8 hrs (over 2 days)
Hooker Valley easy	Mt Cook & Mackenzie	Thu 19–Sat 21	10 km (return)	~185 m	~3 hrs

~ = estimate.

✅ BOOKED

Mon 9	Lake Mackenzie Hut — 1 spot (Courtney)
Mon 16	Brewster Hut — 3 spots
Sun 22	LYLO Airport hostel — backup (C & R)

📝 TO BOOK / SORT

Tue 10	Earnslaw Burn — bring tents
Wed 11	Cascade Creek Campsite
Thu 12	Spot near Wanaka
Fri 13	Liverpool OR French Ridge Hut — 5 spots
Sat 14	Wanaka OR Kidds Bush (paid)
Sun 15	Fox Glacier / West Coast campsite
Mon 16	Brewster — 2 more hut OR camping spots
Tue 17	Wanaka campsite
Wed 18–20	Lake Poaka (free)
Thu 19–20	Mueller Hut — watch for cancellations
Sat 21	Lake Tekapo campsite
Sun 22	Spot near Christchurch Airport

🌙 NIGHTS

Queenstown	3
Earnslaw Burn	1
Cascade Creek	1
Wanaka area	3
Aspiring huts	1
West Coast	1
Brewster Hut	1
Twizel / Pukaki	3
Lake Tekapo	1
Christchurch	1

🎒 OVERNIGHT HIKE KIT

- ☐ 40L+ backpack
- ☐ Sleeping bag
- ☐ Sleeping mat
- ☐ Tent with footprint
- ☐ Toilet paper & trowel
- ☐ Head torch (3am Roys Peak)
- ☐ Rain jacket & overtrousers
- ☐ Thermals, puffer, beanie, gloves
- ☐ Warm layers for 2am Dark Sky
- ☐ Broken-in boots & spare socks
- ☐ Stove, gas, lighter, pot, spork
- ☐ Dehydrated meals & snacks
- ☐ Water bottles + filter / tablets
- ☐ First aid & blister kit
- ☐ Sunscreen, sunnies, hat
- ☐ Sandfly repellent
- ☐ Map, compass & PLB (Brewster Glacier)
- ☐ Power bank
- ☐ Rubbish bag — pack it out
- ☐ Hut booking confirmations

NOTES

⚠️ **Aoraki Mt Cook camping** — no availability at White Horse Hill Campground yet, so we may need to stay in Twizel or near Lake Pukaki (~40 min drive; closest town).

⚠️ **Mueller Hut** — no overnight availability yet. Last-minute cancellations happen, but 5 spots aren't guaranteed. If staying up there matters to you, bring a tent. If we all stay on the mountain we'll also need a White Horse Hill spot; otherwise 1+ people hike down in the day, park the van in Twizel and come back next day to meet everyone 🥲

⚠️ **Weather** — Mt Cook plans are very weather-dependent and may change at short notice (last time I was there, Mt Cook wasn't visible half the time).

Hike figures from DOC and track guides. Calories assume ~70 kcal per km with a pack; a Cookie Time cookie is 402 kcal. Gain = total climb.